



Receive and resolve customer complaints

D1.HRS.CL1.15

Trainee Manual



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Trainee Manual



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Introduction to trainee manual

To the Trainee

Congratulations on joining this course. This Trainee Manual is one part of a 'toolbox' which is a resource provided to trainees, trainers and assessors to help you become competent in various areas of your work.

The 'toolbox' consists of three elements:

- A Trainee Manual for you to read and study at home or in class
- A Trainer Guide with Power Point slides to help your Trainer explain the content of the training material and provide class activities to help with practice
- An Assessment Manual which provides your Assessor with oral and written questions and other assessment tasks to establish whether or not you have achieved competency.

The first thing you may notice is that this training program and the information you find in the Trainee Manual seems different to the textbooks you have used previously. This is because the method of instruction and examination is different. The method used is called Competency based training (CBT) and Competency based assessment (CBA). CBT and CBA is the training and assessment system chosen by ASEAN (Association of South-East Asian Nations) to train people to work in the tourism and hospitality industry throughout all the ASEAN member states.

What is the CBT and CBA system and why has it been adopted by ASEAN?

CBT is a way of training that concentrates on what a worker can do or is required to do at work. The aim of the training is to enable trainees to perform tasks and duties at a standard expected by employers. CBT seeks to develop the skills, knowledge and attitudes (or recognise the ones the trainee already possesses) to achieve the required competency standard. ASEAN has adopted the CBT/CBA training system as it is able to produce the type of worker that industry is looking for and this therefore increases trainee's chances of obtaining employment.

CBA involves collecting evidence and making a judgement of the extent to which a worker can perform his/her duties at the required competency standard. Where a trainee can already demonstrate a degree of competency, either due to prior training or work experience, a process of 'Recognition of Prior Learning' (RPL) is available to trainees to recognise this. Please speak to your trainer about RPL if you think this applies to you.

What is a competency standard?

Competency standards are descriptions of the skills and knowledge required to perform a task or activity at the level of a required standard.

242 competency standards for the tourism and hospitality industries throughout the ASEAN region have been developed to cover all the knowledge, skills and attitudes required to work in the following occupational areas:

- Housekeeping
- Food Production
- Food and Beverage Service

- Front Office
- Travel Agencies
- Tour Operations.

All of these competency standards are available for you to look at. In fact you will find a summary of each one at the beginning of each Trainee Manual under the heading 'Unit Descriptor'. The unit descriptor describes the content of the unit you will be studying in the Trainee Manual and provides a table of contents which are divided up into 'Elements' and 'Performance Criteria'. An element is a description of one aspect of what has to be achieved in the workplace. The 'Performance Criteria' below each element details the level of performance that needs to be demonstrated to be declared competent.

There are other components of the competency standard:

- *Unit Title*: statement about what is to be done in the workplace
- *Unit Number*: unique number identifying the particular competency
- *Nominal hours*: number of classroom or practical hours usually needed to complete the competency. We call them 'nominal' hours because they can vary e.g. sometimes it will take an individual less time to complete a unit of competency because he/she has prior knowledge or work experience in that area.

The final heading you will see before you start reading the Trainee Manual is the 'Assessment Matrix'. Competency based assessment requires trainees to be assessed in at least 2 – 3 different ways, one of which must be practical. This section outlines three ways assessment can be carried out and includes work projects, written questions and oral questions. The matrix is designed to show you which performance criteria will be assessed and how they will be assessed. Your trainer and/or assessor may also use other assessment methods including 'Observation Checklist' and 'Third Party Statement'. An observation checklist is a way of recording how you perform at work and a third party statement is a statement by a supervisor or employer about the degree of competence they believe you have achieved. This can be based on observing your workplace performance, inspecting your work or gaining feedback from fellow workers.

Your trainer and/or assessor may use other methods to assess you such as:

- Journals
- Oral presentations
- Role plays
- Log books
- Group projects
- Practical demonstrations.

Remember your trainer is there to help you succeed and become competent. Please feel free to ask him or her for more explanation of what you have just read and of what is expected from you and best wishes for your future studies and future career in tourism and hospitality.

Unit descriptor

Receive and resolve customer complaints

This unit deals with the skills and knowledge required to Receive and resolve customer complaints in a range of settings within the hotel and travel industries workplace context.

Unit Code:

D1.HRS.CL1.15

Nominal Hours:

25 hours

Element 1: Identify and analyse the complaint

Performance Criteria

- 1.1 Receive and accurately record a verbal complaint using active listening and empathy techniques
- 1.2 Identify through appropriate communication techniques the exact nature of the customer complaint
- 1.3 Maintain register or complaint file/s in accordance with the requirements of the enterprise information system

Element 2: Respond to complaints

Performance Criteria

- 2.1 Process complaints in accordance with organisational standards, policies and procedures
- 2.2 Obtain and review documentation in relation to complaints
- 2.3 Update register of complaints/disputes

Element 3: Determine and agree upon appropriate action to resolve complaint

Performance Criteria

- 3.1 Identify and review options to resolve the complaint within enterprise policy, procedures and guidelines
- 3.2 Agree and confirm action to resolve the complaint with the customer
- 3.3 Demonstrate a commitment to the customer to resolve the complaint
- 3.4 Inform customer of outcome of investigation of complaint

Element 4: Refer complaints

Performance Criteria

- 4.1 Identify complaints that require referral to other personnel or external bodies
- 4.2 Refer complaint to appropriate personnel for follow-up in accordance with individual level of responsibility
- 4.3 Forward all necessary documentation including investigation reports to appropriate personnel
- 4.4 Refer complaints which cannot be resolved to an appropriate person

Assessment matrix

Showing mapping of Performance Criteria against Work Projects, Written Questions and Oral Questions

The Assessment Matrix indicates three of the most common assessment activities your Assessor may use to assess your understanding of the content of this manual and your performance - Work Projects, Written Questions and Oral Questions. It also indicates where you can find the subject content related to these assessment activities in the Trainee Manual (i.e. under which element or performance criteria). As explained in the Introduction, however, the assessors are free to choose which assessment activities are most suitable to best capture evidence of competency as they deem appropriate for individual students.

		Work Projects	Written Questions	Oral Questions
Element 1: Identify and analyse the complaint				
1.1	Receive and accurately record a verbal complaint using active listening and empathy techniques	1.1	1,2	1
1.2	Identify through appropriate communication techniques the exact nature of the customer complaint	1.2	3,4,5	2
1.3	Maintain register or complaint file/s in accordance with the requirements of the enterprise information system	1.3	6	3
Element 2: Respond to complaints				
2.1	Process complaints in accordance with organisational standards, policies and procedures	2.1	7,8	4
2.2	Obtain and review documentation in relation to complaints	2.2	9,10	5
2.3	Update register of complaints/disputes	2.3	11,12	6

		Work Projects	Written Questions	Oral Questions
Element 3: Determine and agree upon appropriate action to resolve complaint				
3.1	Identify and review options to resolve the complaint within enterprise policy, procedures and guidelines	3.1	13,14	7
3.2	Agree and confirm action to resolve the complaint with the customer	3.2	15,16	8
3.3	Demonstrate a commitment to the customer to resolve the complaint	3.3	17	9
3.4	Inform customer of outcome of investigation of complaint	3.4	18,19,20	10
Element 4: Refer complaints				
4.1	Identify complaints that require referral to other personnel or external bodies	4.1	21,22	11
4.2	Refer complaint to appropriate personnel for follow-up in accordance with individual level of responsibility	4.2	23,24	12
4.3	Forward all necessary documentation including investigation reports to appropriate personnel	4.3	25,26	13
4.4	Refer complaints which cannot be resolved to an appropriate person	4.4	27,28	14

Glossary

Term	Explanation
Communication	The imparting or interchange of thoughts, opinions, or information by speech, writing, or signs.
Complaint	An expression of discontent or resentment; fault-finding
Define	To explain or identify
Documentation	Use of different materials as evidence
Escalated complaint	Definition
Ethics	The rules of conduct based on moral principles
Evidence	That which tends to prove or disprove something, ground for belief, proof.
External	Sources outside an organisation
Inconvenience	An inconvenient circumstance or thing, something that causes discomfort, trouble, etc.
Internal	Sources within an organisation
Intoxicated patrons	Customers showing effects of alcohol
Non-verbal communication	Body language
Policy	Set of rules
Procedure	A particular course or mode of action
Referring complaints	Passing the responsibility of a complaint to another person
Solution	The act of solving a problem or complaint
Standard	A stated and often desired level of performance or behaviour

Element 1:

Identify and analyse the complaint

1.1 Receive and accurately record a verbal complaint using active listening and empathy techniques

Introduction

Regardless of how well a business operates, problems will happen. When problems occur, complaints are the common outcome that needs to be addressed. Whether they are caused or perceived by the organisation or the customer themselves, or due to external influences, they must be identified and addressed in a timely manner. In addition they must try to keep both the organisation and customer happy and satisfied with the outcome.



Where there are less than optimum instances of customer service, these problems must be diagnosed so that improved service options can be developed.

Before we explore how to deal with complaints, it is important to understand the background as to how they can arise.

Quite often complaints arise when customer's needs, wishes or expectations are not met.

Customer needs, wishes and expectations

Common problems in relation to customer service revolve around the concepts of customer needs, wishes and expectations.

Customer service centres around an organisation's ability to meet or exceed customer needs, wishes and expectations.

It seems appropriate, then, to identify what these mean.



Needs

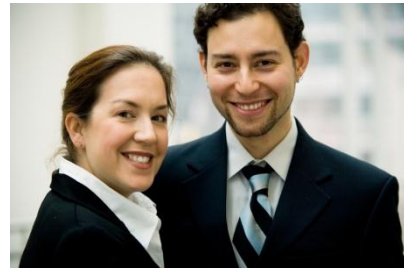
These underlie wishes and expectations and are the things customers are unable to do without. They may be in a foreign town and simply cannot do without a bed for the night, a meal or beverage.

Generic customer needs

Whilst every organisation's customers have their own individual needs, there are a number of generic needs that staff must address when providing quality customer service.

These needs include:

- Value for money
- 'Offering' reflecting what was advertised
- Expectations met/exceeded
- To feel respected. This is why we use "Sir" and "Madam"
- To feel welcomed. This is why we give all our customers a warm, genuine and sincere smile and welcome. We really are pleased to see them
- To be served by friendly staff. This is why we smile and why we spend that extra few seconds with them, talking about how their day went and so on
- To be dealt with in a prompt and courteous manner. This is why we don't keep them waiting at reception, the bar, for room service or for meals
- To receive assistance when necessary. This is the reason why we have excellent product and local knowledge and why we look for opportunities to pass this on to them whenever we can, even without their having to ask
- To be in comfortable, clean surroundings which is why we make sure the facilities, rooms, grounds and equipment are spotless
- To feel remembered and recognised which is why we use the customer's name as often as we can
- To be heard and understood. This is the reason why we listen to complaints and adopt the role of their advocate whenever there is a complaint, problem or dispute. We want to fix their problems, not create new ones.



Specific target market needs

A hospitality and tourism business will have customers from a number of different target markets, each with their own specific needs. It is important that staff recognise the needs of each target market and tailor their service accordingly.

The following are different target markets and their specific needs:

- Business – computer and internet access, newspapers, executive lounges, laundry services, business or executive centre, business and news channels. Businessmen are more likely to frequent a hotel bar and eat in the restaurant
- Women – hairdryers, larger mirrors, healthier food options, specific bathroom amenities, fashion magazines, bath. Business women are more likely to use the gym and eat room service
- Family – interconnecting rooms, costs, entertainment options, child care facilities, children's television programs, handicapped facilities, disabled toilets, package deals and safety
- Leisure – cheaper rates, local attractions, concierge services
- Elderly – single beds, medical facilities, suitable food options and cheaper rates
- Groups – need for large allocation of rooms, cheap rates, meeting rooms, specialised menus, bus access and parking.



Wishes

These refer to the way in which our customer would prefer to satisfy a specific need, but they may not have the resources to meet these wishes. They may wish to stay in the luxury suite, dine at an internationally renowned, 5-star, fine dining restaurant and drink expensive champagne, but they haven't got the money to pay for it so they settle for something else.

Expectations

Customers know they can't afford the luxury mentioned above, but as a result of our advertising and their previous experiences with us, they know they will get a clean and satisfactory room, wholesome food at value for money prices and a good range of drinks at fair prices to pick from, all delivered with great service - so they elect to stay and dine with us.

Our big problems start when what the customer actually experiences is at odds with their expectations.

Customers have perceived expectations of what level of service they expect when visiting a venue arising from:

- The company's image or reputation in the market
- Past visits
- Advertisements and promotional messages
- Competing hotels
- Industry standards
- Comments from family, friends and colleagues
- Price charged for the offering.



Complaints

As mentioned, complaints arise when customer's needs, wishes or expectations are not met.

Complaints are a common part of any organisation. Every day complaints will be made by a customer. Given that most hotels have over 300 customers a day, it is unrealistic to think that everyone will be happy, every day.

It is important to remember that any complaint really is an opportunity to rectify a problem, or make a long-lasting customer, providing they are dealt with quickly, properly and fully.

Complaints can come in an array of circumstances and be based on endless situations. Regardless of the situation there is a standard approach which can be applied to help resolve the complaint.

The standards should specify the steps to be taken for a range of complaints. There are several predictable complaints we are likely to get and it may be possible to foresee the majority of them.

The standards should spell out the discretionary power that staff have to fix a complaint to the benefit of the customer.



Whilst acknowledging we do not want to be exploited on the issue of complaints it is worth bearing in mind that no-one ever won an argument with a customer, and for every customer who actually does complain, there are probably another ten with grounds to, but who haven't.

Simply stated, customers like to have their complaint treated seriously, acted on quickly and be apologised to.

It is important to deal with all complaints in a friendly, efficient and thorough manner.

Three keys in responding to customer complaints are to be:

- Positive
- Sensitive
- Polite.



Types of complaints

Before we look at the processes involved in handling customer complaints, let's have a look at the different types of common customer complaints.

Whilst the actual range of complaints will be endless there are a number of common complaints evident in most tourism and hospitality organisations.



- Rude staff and management. This is a major cause of customer complaints
- Difficult or demanding customers. Some customers are especially difficult to deal with and extremely demanding in their orders and the way they 'ask' for service
- Lack of service, or poor, service. This can involve the customer having to wait 'too long', the quality of products being sub-standard, staff who are disrespectful, rude or offensive when they deliver service
- Expectations not being met. The advertisements that your venue runs, coupled with word of mouth advertising, create these expectations and they may often be unrealistic. Customers can be frustrated and disappointed when reality fails to match either the advertisements or the expectations, and conflict can often result. This classification is a common one with special needs customers
- Dissatisfaction with the accommodation, for example, the room facilities are not working, are out-dated, the room may smell of smoke, be too noisy or the view is not what was anticipated
- Services are poor; details may have been forgotten or the general level of service is insufficient and slow
- Unhygienic conditions. The guest room or any facility enjoyed by customers shows a lack of proper attention to detail and incorrect housekeeping practices.
- Low comfort levels, for example, an area of the property could have been too cold, too noisy, or too crowded



- Rowdy and unacceptable behaviour displayed by other customers, for example, the room or table next to the customer may have been patronised by a noisy and boisterous customer
- A mistake with an account, for example, the guest account may have charged for items that should have been on someone else's bill, or overcharged for a product or service
- Error in the reservation or booking or not found. The guest may have arrived to find there was a problem with a booking or reservation that they had been led to believe was guaranteed and problem-free
- Special requests not being adhered to. The flowers and champagne that were ordered for 4:00 PM were not delivered and spoiled a very special occasion
- Limited or no rooms/tables available. Every business has a capacity on how many customers can be served, seated or accommodated at one time
- Requirement to guarantee a reservation. Many organisations will have guarantee policy to ensure they can maximise revenues for outlets. If inflexible conditions exist, it may irritate potential or existing customers
- Lack of flexibility of methods of payment. A customer, for example, may wish to offer payment which the establishment may not accept. Possible situations may include an organisation's refusal to take cheque or American Express payments
- Hidden charges. This may include taxes or service fees the customer did not expect of was not told about
- Ejection from the premises. If a customer has to be removed from the premises for whatever reason.



Warning signs of a complaint

Usually, before someone makes a complaint, they give outward signs of their dissatisfaction.

Whilst this may be easy to see when the customer is in front of you, such as at Front Office or in the restaurant, it is certainly harder to anticipate when they complain over the phone or after they have left the premises.

In addition, some departments may have to deal with complaints, even if it stems from another department. This is a common occurrence where check out reception staff may receive complaints in relation to any facet of their stay at the hotel.

Where the customer has come to make a face to face complaint, it is essential to pick up on these signs before an unnecessary incident occurs.

Some signs of dissatisfaction include negative changes in:

- Body language
- Voice
- Actions.



Common actions a guest may make when about to complain includes:

- Look angry or aggressive
- Appear flustered or frustrated
- Display contorted facial expressions
- Glance around as if seeking assistance
- Physically touch another guest or colleague
- Become too loud
- Become argumentative.

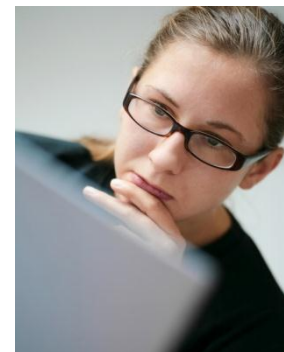


At all times, you should be alert to the above warning signs.

Delivery of complaints

There are a number of ways in which a complaint is brought to the attention of staff and management. These include, but are certainly not limited to:

- Written complaints – including by letter, email, complaint or customer feedback forms
- Verbal – face to face complaints
- Verbal - complaints over the telephone.



Regardless of how a complaint is received, it must be dealt with in a professional manner.

Deal with complaints sensitively, courteously and discreetly

When handling all complaint situations it is important to deal with them in a friendly, efficient, respectful, courteous and thorough manner.

In short, we must be sensitive to the customer, their needs, the nature of the complaint and the mood the customer is in.

The customer must be given the time to explain the situation fully, without staff or management cutting them short or placing words into their mouths.

It cannot be emphasised enough how important it is for the person to express their views as many complaints can be successfully sorted out simply by allowing the person involved to get whatever it is 'off their chest'.



Being sensitive

Being sensitive when dealing with a customer complaint asks you to:

- Take time (5 – 10 seconds is often enough) to assess the environment in which the complaint is taking place. This helps to contextualise the complaint, and allows time to gather information about what is happening. This is beneficial because things are seldom what they appear to be at first glance

- Factor in relevant issues which may include cultural and social issues, age, race, gender, whether the person is a regular or local, if the person is tired, if they are ill, if they are drug or alcohol-affected.

It is important to note 'nationality' can be a significant, important and influential factor in relation to complaints: different cultures and different religions may cause different problems.

- Approach each situation appropriately. A smile in one situation can be appropriate, while a serious facial expression may be better in another context
- Make requests and suggestions to people as opposed to making demands of them, or giving them directions or ultimatums. Always be careful about giving ultimatums. If you are going to give an ultimatum you better be prepared and able to carry out whatever the ultimatum is or you lose credibility and risk having all your subsequent decisions rejected.

While you are required to act sensitively when dealing with a complaint you must also comply with all organisational and legal requirements. The aim of being sensitive can never override your need to 'comply' with your legal obligations.

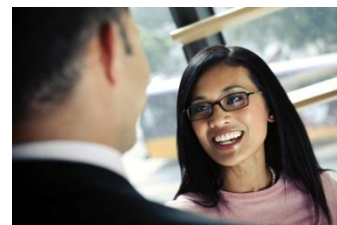
Being courteous

Being courteous means being polite.

The theory is that if you are courteous to someone else, they will be courteous in return. Similarly, the theory goes, if you are rude and offensive, they will also be rude and offensive and this will only fuel and escalate the conflict.

Being courteous when dealing with conflict asks you to:

- Use people's names, where known or use 'Sir' or 'Madam'
- Say 'please' when asking them to do something
- Say 'thank you' if they comply with a request
- Demonstrate respect for them as a person:
 - Don't invade their personal space
 - Don't touch them
 - Don't use put-downs when talking to them
 - Ignore their initial hostile response to your intervention. Never meet aggression with aggression. It is, if the situation warrants it, OK to be assertive but is never acceptable to be aggressive
- Use open gestures as opposed to intimidating ones or closed body language.



Being discreet

Being discreet when dealing with complaints asks you to:

- Talk quietly to the person
- Remove the person to another area, if possible
- Take whatever action is appropriate to deal with the situation without drawing unnecessary attention to it.



Taking swift action

By identifying the risk of a possible complaint via a warning sign you will have a greater chance of stopping it from escalating into an unwanted situation.

The moment you identify one of these warning signs, you should do everything in your power to stop the problem getting worse. This means you must take swift action and act in a tactful manner. Not acting is the worst thing you can do.

The majority of complaints can be overcome, or simply avoided if someone does something. The customer has to see that we are taking their problem seriously and that we are doing something about it.

Greeting the customer

The first thing to do when a customer comes with a complaint is to:

- Greet them
- Identify yourself
- Identify who the guest is
- Thank them for bringing the complaint to their attention
- Offer assistance in trying to find a suitable solution to their complaint
- Take the person to a suitable location where it will not interfere with other customers and where the customer with the complaint feels comfortable
- Depending on the situation, you may wish to offer them refreshment.



1.2 Identify through appropriate communication techniques the exact nature of the customer complaint

Introduction

Once we have greeted the customer, one of the most important aspects of handling customer complaints effectively is through the use of effective communication.

All communications with customers should be conducted in an open, professional and friendly manner. The need to do this when handling complaints is even more important.

Use effective communication and interpersonal techniques

Dealing effectively with complaint situations requires the use of a blend of communication and interpersonal skills.

Communication skills

Communication involves sending and receiving messages:

- Verbally – listening, questioning and speaking
- Non-verbally – body language which comprises facial expressions, eye contact, gestures and posture.

Interpersonal skills

The following skills are important for effective workplace communication.

- Face the person you are talking with
- Maintain eye contact if possible
- Address the person by their name
- Establish a rapport.



Listening

At this time the most important thing to do is to listen so you can:

- Identify the main points of the complaint
- Separate the actual aspects of the complaint from the emotion.



Whilst it is hard to sit and listen to a complaint, especially when you are not the cause of it, we must be sensitive to the customer, their needs, the nature of the conflict and the mood the customer is in.

The customer must be given the time to explain the situation fully, without the manager interrupting, cutting them short or placing words into their mouth.

It cannot be emphasised enough how important it is for the person to say their piece.

Many conflicts can be successfully sorted out simply by allowing the person involved to get whatever it is 'off their chest'.

Listening to the issue and making sure you have a full understanding of what is the cause of the problem. You have to make sure you are treating the root cause and not a symptom.

Listen to everything the customer has to say even though it may be the last thing that you feel like doing! Recognise and respect the customer's thoughts and feelings. Show genuine interest in their needs and expectations.

When listening, not only are you trying to determine the cause of the problem, but what they may feel to be a suitable solution to it. By having an understanding of what they are expecting at an early stage, it may help you when offering solutions.

To be an active listener you must be able to concentrate well.

Questioning

Asking the right questions at the right time is an important part of being an effective communicator in your dealings with complaints.

Asking questions also enables you to:

- Acquire more accurate information
- Identify what the other person wants in order to solve the complaint



- Demonstrate you are actively and genuinely interested in resolving the complaint
- Clarify ambiguities
- Better understand contexts.

You can save a lot of time in complaint situations, reduce anxieties and the potential for conflict by correctly structuring your questions.

Questions can be asked in many ways, but they all fall into two broad categories: 'closed' questions or 'open' questions.

Closed questions

Ask closed questions to clarify or confirm information

Closed questions are questions that can be answered with a simple 'Yes' or 'No' answer.

For example:

- "Can you hear the noise in the next room?"
- "Is the noise excessive?"
- "Did the noise last for 30 minutes?"

Open questions

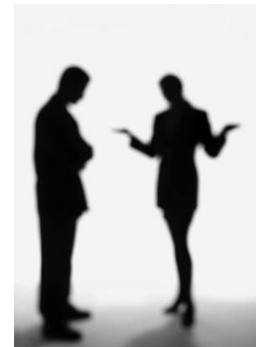
Asking open questions is often used to gain more information.

Open questions are questions that cannot be answered with a 'Yes' or a 'No' and generally start with "Who", "What", "When", "Why" and "How". For example:

- "Who did you speak with, Sir?"
- "What kind of service did you require?"
- "How long did the noise last for?"

Useful techniques when questioning people to obtain information about a complaint or to determine a possible solution are to:

- Rephrase or repeat questions
- Paraphrase the responses they have given you.



Body language – non-verbal communication

Non-verbal communication occurs in all person to person situations. It is impossible for it not to happen.

Some people use more non-verbal communication than others do, but we all use it to some degree.

Observing customer's body language

When we listen and question, we are also:

- Watching to identify non-verbal communication
- Analysing what the person is saying



- Interpreting the words and the body language to understand the person and their message, to make sense of it and to determine what the response should be.

Transmitting body language

You need to pay attention to the messages your body language is sending when dealing with a conflict situation. As we make an effort to read the other person's body language, they will also be reading ours as well.

Forms of body language important in conflict situations include:

- Your stance and posture
- Your facial expressions
- How you hold your arms.

Body language therefore transmits feelings.

We must take care that these 'emotional messages' cannot be interpreted as conflicting with the verbal message sent. Where your body language says one thing but your words say another, people tend to believe the non-verbal communication.

It is extremely important to be consciously aware of your body language at all times when communicating face to face in a complaint situation, and to realise that the total interaction involves much, much more than just the spoken word.

Recording complaint details

Write information

When the customer is talking, it is important that you write the information down. You may want to ask the customer before they start to explain their complaint, if they mind if you write down information. In most cases they will welcome this suggestion. Not only does this help identify the actual aspects of the complaint, but shows you have taken the complaint seriously.

Repeat information

Once the customer has finished explaining their complaint, it is worthwhile to repeat back the complaint to the customer. This allows you to establish the scope and nature of the problem along with any history that might accompany it.

Repeating information is important as it:

- Shows that you have indeed been listening
- States the complaint, without the emotion, normally making the complaint less serious
- Ensures the complaint is correct
- Acts as a basis to work towards a solution.



Speaking

Now that we have listened and asked questions to identify the aspects of the complaint it is now time to work towards finding an acceptable solution.

It is our time to speak and to start the process towards reaching a solution to the complaint.

The effectiveness of our communication will be influenced by various elements of our speech.

These elements are:

- Pitch or tone
- Intensity
- Projection
- The pauses we use in our speech.



You might find occasions when it is appropriate for you to raise your voice to a friend or family member, but you should never raise your voice when speaking with a customer.

This may not only be seen as rude, but can be interpreted as being threatening, or lacking in self-confidence.

To be an effective communicator, it is important to pick your words carefully. Always be aware of the type of person you are speaking with and modify your language to suit the listener as much as possible.

It has been said so many times that it loses its effect but it's true. Every one of our customers is an individual and must be treated as such.

Stay calm and positive

At all times, when responding to conflicts and customer complaints you must maintain a positive and cooperative manner with other parties.

This is quite easy to say, but often proves much more difficult to actually do.

A positive and cooperative manner can help to:

- Smooth over a potentially problematic situation. Many complaints can be quickly and effectively handled by staff adopting the 'right attitude' to the complaint. Lots of customers simply want to air their grievance. They don't expect anything to happen. They just want to be heard to get it off their chest
- Demonstrate your willingness to resolve the issue as opposed to ignoring it or dismissing it out of hand. This respects the customer as an individual and sends a definite signal that the individual is of value to the business
- Create an initial friendly atmosphere. An approach that indicates a willingness to listen to, and work with, the customer will always set the foundation for a faster and more acceptable resolution. It is much more difficult for the customer to maintain their rage when the staff are displaying a friendly, helpful and courteous orientation to the problem



- Maintain positive customer relations. It is a standard requirement of all enterprises that complaints be seen as 'opportunities'. Managers are expected to achieve a final outcome to the complaint that will maintain the person complaining as an on-going customer.

Apologise for problem and inconvenience

One of the first things that we communicate in our response is to acknowledge that a complaint exists.

Most customers who have a problem simply leave a visit without notifying anyone of the inconvenience that has been caused. Not only will they not return, but in the majority of cases they will also let their family, friends and acquaintances know of the poor experience they received.



As most people don't enjoy being in an uncomfortable and confronting situation, they will normally just leave.

Therefore it is important that when a customer does come to us with a complaint that we handle it in a professional manner and acknowledge the inconvenience the problem has caused.

Acknowledge the problem

Not only must the manager thank the customer for bringing the complaint to them, they must also acknowledge that a problem has occurred and apologise for it. It is the least they can do at this stage. It is not expected that the problem can be resolved instantaneously, however an apology can go a long way before a resolution can be found.

Acknowledge the inconvenience

Not only is it important to acknowledge that a problem exists, but also that it has caused an inconvenience for the customer. In many cases, people come to hotels for a chance to relax and take a break from their busy lives. They place a high importance on this time and anything that can disturb it can not only take a physical but emotional toll.

A manager must place themselves in the customer's shoes and understand how the problem has negatively impacted on the customer.



Clarify details of complaint

As mentioned, it is important to write down the complaint, as it helps to identify the main aspects of the complaint.

An essential factor in resolving complaints is that the nature and details of the conflict are identified and accepted by everyone as being at the heart of the issue.

Until these details are accepted no real movement towards an effective solution can occur because no-one really understands exactly what it is they are trying to resolve.

This step avoids a situation where we are responding to the symptoms of a complaint, and not the cause.

Once again, the nature of some complaints is such that this step will not be able to occur.

Defining the complaint

Establishing the nature and details of the complaint is often referred to as 'defining the conflict' – working out the heart of the problem and the parameters that apply.

It serves to clarify precisely what is involved in the issue so that everyone can see the real issue that needs to be addressed.



In most cases, those involved will tell you what the problem is, but their statement is certain to leave out some relevant information. This information may be information which lessens their case, or which puts a different slant on their allegations. Or it may be information that would really help them if they only knew it.

The fact remains that you must talk to the person and ask questions to flesh out the full nature of the conflict.

When talking to the person(s) you should attempt to find out various bits of information. The more detailed and accurate the information, the better:

- Names of those involved
- Details of times, dates, figures, amounts
- Identification of exact service or products that failed to live up to promises or expectations, including how they failed to deliver on quality or expectations
- The factual details, as far as can be determined, as to what was done or said and by whom
- Actions or inactions taken (or not taken) by staff or other people.



Handling alcohol related complaints

Whilst most complaints are not influenced by alcohol, it is important to handle these situations, when they arise, in a professional manner.

Most people behave differently when affected by drink and it is to be expected that people who have had too much to drink will not behave as they do when they are sober.

They too may become more aggressive, they may become more romantically inclined or they may just become tired and want to go to sleep, but the odds are that their behaviour will alter.

Add to this the ever present possibility that some customers may be drug-affected and you start to appreciate the reality of many businesses.

In any business there will always be complaints that will be brought to the attention of staff and management.

When alcohol is involved, the number and types of complaints may vary. Some may be logical whilst others unreasonable and resulting from the requests of people who are intoxicated or under the influence of alcohol.



Dealing with a complaint can be complicated. If you handle it well, you will have brought the customer round from being dissatisfied to being happy. However, if dealt with badly, the customer will feel even more unhappy and is likely to tell as many people as possible about the situation, leading to a loss of potential customers.

Quite often intoxicated people will just complain and any solution you may offer, whilst reasonable to you, may never satisfy their needs.

Regardless of the complaint, key points to dealing with them include:

- Listen carefully to the complaint, without interrupting
- Show that you understand
- Apologise
- Seek a solution.

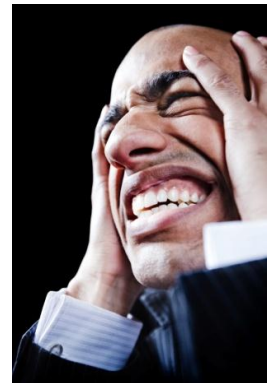
It is important to remain professional and treat every complaint with respect, even if it does not warrant it.

Remember, when people are angry, they often throw insults. Do not take insults personally or retaliate; you have to remain professional.

Dealing with complaints requires you to have patience and to keep others around you calm.

Some tips for handling alcohol related complaints include:

- Identify situations where problems may arise as early as possible
- Try to involve the customer by providing options
- Treat the customer professionally
- Don't touch the customer, where possible
- Take action as early as possible
- Follow all house policies, rules and regulations.



When handling any situation involving an intoxicated individual, always think of how you would like to be treated if the roles were reversed.

Agree on the nature and details of the complaint

This is a fairly straightforward stage that requires you to:

- Repeat back to the person what they have told you
- Elicit additional information and clarification
- Obtain assurance that what they have told you constitutes the entire complaint and that, if that can be effectively resolved, that will be an end to the matter
- Confirm they are genuinely seeking a solution to what has been described as opposed to wanting the matter to drag on and on.



While this is a relatively simple stage of the overall complaint resolution process, it is a vital one because it provides the basis for considering options that can be implemented to resolve the problem.

1.3 Maintain register or complaint file/s in accordance with the requirements of the enterprise information system

Introduction

Whenever a complaint is received it is common policy for many hospitality establishments to keep a written record of it. In the previous section, the taking of notes was identified to help identify the key elements of a complaint.

This starts the documentation process and acts as the basis for any future communication and action.

Benefits of written documentation

There are many benefits to having written documentation in relation to complaints as it:

- Establishes a clear record of facts relating to a complaint
- Identifies any communication or action taken place to date
- Keeps facts of a complaint accurate and impartial
- Is helpful for additional internal and external parties who may later become involved in the complaint resolution process
- Can be used as a reference for similar complaints in the future
- Acts as an evidence source if additional costs are incurred
- Acts as a tool to identify common problems which are to be investigated
- Generates a pool of 'guest preferences' which can be used in the future to avoid further complaints.



Complete any necessary documentation accurately

Whilst, as seen above, completing documentation is essential, house policies vary significantly in their requirement for staff to complete necessary documentation during the complaint resolution process.

This variation in approaches can often be related to difficulties in, and different approaches to, defining exactly what a 'complaint situation' is for each venue.

Necessary documentation can include internal forms and reports as well as mandatory registers.

Regardless of the documentation to be used, all information recorded should be completed:

- Accurately and honestly
- Clearly
- Comprehensively.

It is imperative that all staff have an understanding of:

- The internal forms and reports that need to be completed
- The mandatory registers that need to be completed such as those of a serious nature including injury, theft, liquor and gaming issues
- What events give rise to the need to complete these forms, reports or registers
- Who is allowed to complete them
- The time within which they must be completed.



It is a good idea to look at the entries that exist in the mandatory registers and the internal documentation to gain an understanding and appreciation of the style that is used and the details that are recorded.

Work Projects

It is a requirement of this Unit that you complete Work Projects as advised by your Trainer. You must submit documentation, suitable evidence or other relevant proof of completion of the project to your Trainer by the agreed date.

- 1.1 To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to research and identify different types of complaints in the hospitality industry including causes for them.
 - 1.2 To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to research and identify:
 - How to clarify the details of the complaint
 - Different communication techniques that can be used when handling customer complaints.
 - 1.3 To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to research and identify:
 - Different types of written communication that needs to be completed when recording complaints
 - The benefits of having written documentation relating to complaints.
-

Summary

Identify and analyse the complaint

Receive and accurately record a verbal complaint using active listening and empathy techniques:

- Customer needs, wishes and expectations
- Complaints
- Types of complaints
- Warning signs of a complaint
- Delivery of complaints
- Deal with complaints sensitively, courteously and discreetly
- Taking swift action
- Greeting the customer.

Identify through appropriate communication techniques the exact nature of the customer's complaint:

- Use effective communication and interpersonal techniques
- Listening
- Questioning
- Body language – non-verbal communication
- Recording complaint details
- Speaking
- Stay calm and positive
- Apologise for problem and inconvenience
- Clarify details of complaint
- Handling alcohol related complaints
- Agree on the nature and details of the complaint.

Maintain register or complaint file/s in accordance with the requirements of the enterprise's information system:

- Benefits of written documentation
- Complete any necessary documentation accurately.

Element 2: Respond to complaints

2.1 Process complaints in accordance with organisational standards, policies and procedures

Introduction

Once complaints have been received, agreed and documented it is now time to process the complaint to hopefully find a solution that is of benefit to both the customer and the organisation.

In many cases there may be limited research or evidence collection that may need to take place. However, it is essential that the complaint is taken seriously with necessary consideration given.



In the event of a serious complaint, such as theft, gross misconduct, harassment or food poisoning, to name but a few, a comprehensive investigation process may need to take place.

Whilst it is important to find a resolution to a complaint in a timely manner, it is also important to explore and understand the causes of it, so hopefully similar types of complaints can be avoided in the future.

Organisational standards, policies and procedures

When processing complaints they must be done in compliance with organisational standards, policies and procedures.

Naturally these will differ depending on the nature of the complaint and the requirements of each establishment.

Code of ethics

Each organisation, embedded in their culture, will have a code of ethics which is established to ensure that all customer complaints are handled in a serious and professional manner.

A code of ethics also referred to as a code of conduct, outlines how it will handle various issues including customer complaints.



The code of ethics in relation to customer complaints may focus on ensuring:

- Complaints can be submitted easily
- All complaints are taken seriously
- Timely responses are given in a prompt and polite manner
- All action will be communicated in a timely manner
- Complaints will be investigated and where possible, learnt from
- All complaints will remain confidential or to protect the privacy of parties.



Quality systems, standards and guidelines

Each organisation will have an accepted level of performance that must be obtained in handling customer complaints.

These may include stated:

- Objectives
- Rules
- Guidelines.

Scope of authority

At times, you may not have the authority to handle a complaint which comes before you.

While it is vital to quickly identify and take appropriate and swift action in response to conflict situations, no staff member ever has unlimited authority to act.

All staff are under a legal obligation to only act within their specifically assigned scope of authority.

All staff and management are given guidelines as to what action they can take in the workplace without having to get special permission from higher management.

This is referred to as their 'scope of authority'.

The scope of authority may relate to:

- Their ability to act on behalf of the venue
- Their authority to spend money on behalf of the venue
- Their authority to act in given situations, such as when there is a complaint as well as in emergencies, conflict situations, accepting bookings or making special deals.



In relation to resolving customer conflicts, establishments may give staff and management standard scopes of authority to respond in one (or more) standard ways such as:

- Providing a replacement item
- Moving a guest
- Providing a discount or full refund.

Once a complaint has escalated into a conflict, you must take responsibility for finding a solution to the conflict within the scope of your authority.

The solution to the conflict will vary depending on the type of conflict encountered, and the type of conflict will also help to dictate the actions to take.



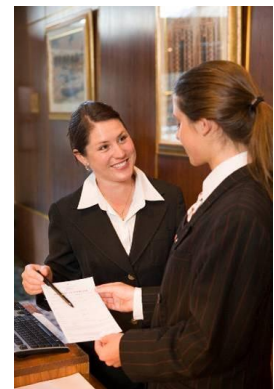
In any situations where you believe a complaint to be beyond either your expertise to resolve, or outside your delegated area of authority, you must refer this type of complaint to the appropriate person.

Written policies of the venue together with an understanding about your individual scope of authority will help you work out whether or not the complaint needs to be referred.

Complaints procedures

All organisations will have set procedures that must be followed in the event that a customer complaint has been submitted. These procedures identify:

- How complaints can be lodged
- Who can handle the complaints
- Timelines for handling complaints
- Timelines and documents to be completed
- Reporting process
- Level of authority
- Steps to follow if complaint process or decision is not satisfactory.



Organisational standard report forms

Each organisation will have their own reports and templates that must be completed as part of the complaint resolution process.

Third party documents

Not only will establishments require you to follow certain guidelines or procedures, in cases where external parties will be required to handle aspects of a complaint, they will have their own policies and procedures that must be addressed and followed. This includes documentation required by:

- Police
- Medical / hospitals

- Insurance companies
- Embassies and consulates
- Airlines, car hire and other transportation providers.

As can be seen in this section there are many influencing factors that must be taken into account when processing complaints.

Whilst there many appear to be many influences, they are designed to serve a purpose that each and every customer complaint is handled in a professional and timely manner.



2.2 Obtain and review documentation in relation to complaints

Introduction

One of the key requirements of any investigatory activity in relation to a customer complaint is to collect evidence of problems that have led to the complaint itself.

As mentioned in Section 1.1 of this manual, the purpose of collecting evidence helps to identify:

- Truth behind a complaint
- Extent of the complaint
- Cause of the problem
- Who is responsible
- Level of liability
- Areas for improvement in the future.



Whilst it is not common, complaining customers may stretch the truth of their claim in order to gain greater compensation or to receive more entitlements than that they should legitimately receive. Whilst an organisation should not believe customer claims, this process helps to determine many aspects of the claim to determine what is accurate.

By collecting evidence, the truth of a complaint becomes clear to all parties.

Identify sources of problems

Where complaints take place, there must be a reason why a specific problem has taken place.

We need to consider the source of problems because in some instances the reason might lie with the organisation, whilst at other times, it might lie with the customer.

Whilst identifying the cause of a problem is essential in resolving complaints, similarly, management cannot hope to resolve problems if they don't understand its many sources.

Employee qualities

Problems may stem from the employee themselves and can include:

- Person is new to the role
- Person does not understand what they need to do

- Person does not have the knowledge and skills to do the task
- Person may have personal problems
- Person cannot handle stressful situations
- Physical problems, such as lack of energy, restricted movement, pain or illness.



Organisational sources

The origin of poor performance in the employee can sometimes be attributed to the organisation. These could include:

- Limited training
- Lack of supervision, direction, instruction or explanation by management
- Ineffective rostering of staff
- Bad physical work environment and unsafe conditions
- Ineffective work processes
- Faulty equipment or power cuts.



Customer sources

At times, the complaint may be directly influenced by the customer including:

- Large amount of customers coming at the same time
- Difficult customers
- Unreasonable requests.

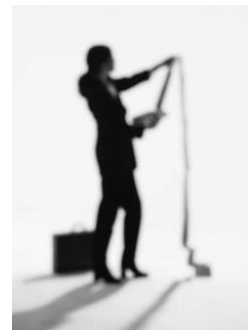


Collecting evidence relating to the complaint

Whilst identifying the cause of the problem is an essential element of the complaint investigation process, it is still important to collect evidence that can help back up a complaint.

This evidence may come in the form of:

- Invoices
- Discussions with staff
- Discussions with other customers
- Reviewing of surveillance equipment
- Cashiering discrepancy reports
- Observations
- Findings from external investigations.



Only by having concrete evidence can the true nature of a complaint be determined. This is essential when trying to determine the most appropriate solution.

2.3 Update register of complaints/disputes

Introduction

During the evidence collection process, any new information should be updated in the complaint file or to meet the requirements of an establishment's complaint resolution procedure.

Importance of updated information

Having an updated and accurate file or folio that contains all the relevant information relating to a customer complaint allows any interested internal or external party or organisation to have access to accurate information.

Information to contain in file

Whilst each organisation will have their own requirements, information that may be kept in a file or folio relating to a customer complaint may include:

- Details of the person making the complaint
- Details of the complaint
- Chronological order of events
- Summary of discussions or activities taken
- Record of persons involved
- Evidence collected
- Recommendations.



Once all information and evidence relating to a customer complaint has been gathered it is now time to find a solution that is acceptable to all parties concerned.

This will be discussed in the next section.

Work Projects

It is a requirement of this Unit that you complete Work Projects as advised by your Trainer. You must submit documentation, suitable evidence or other relevant proof of completion of the project to your Trainer by the agreed date.

2.1 To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to research and identify:

- The different organisational standards, policies and procedures that influence the processing of complaints.

2.2. To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to research and identify:

- The different types of evidence that can be collected when trying to determine the facts behind a customer complaint.

2.3. To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to discuss the importance of having updated information in a register.

Summary

Respond to complaints

Process complaints in accordance with organisational standards, policies and procedures:

- Organisational standards, policies and procedures
- Code of ethics
- Quality systems, standards and guidelines
- Scope of authority
- Complaints procedures
- Organisational standard report forms
- Third party documents.

Obtain and review documentation in relation to complaints:

- Identify sources of problems
- Collecting evidence relating to the complaint.

Maintain register of complaints/disputes:

- Importance of updated information
- Information to contain in file.

Element 3: Determine and agree upon appropriate action to resolve complaint

3.1 Identify and review options to resolve the complaint within enterprise policy, procedures and guidelines

Introduction

Now is the time to discuss and identify a possible solution to the problem.

Most complaints can be effectively resolved by more than one solution.

Your aim must be to find a resolution that is:

- Quick, easy and practical to implement
- Satisfies those involved
- Meets the limitations imposed on you by the law and organisational requirements
- Frequently the best solution for the customer is not the best option for the venue and vice versa.



Compromise is often an essential ingredient from both parties.

Determining possible solutions

The speed with which viable solutions can be identified often depends on the willingness or readiness of parties to communicate, negotiate or compromise.

When proposing possible solutions there are a number of things to take into consideration. These include:

- What the customer wants
- Taking into account all points of view
- Organisational policies
- Pre-programmed decisions
- Non-programmed decisions.



What the customer wants

One easy way to find out how to resolve the complaint is to encourage the customer to identify what will solve the issue. Quite often all they may seek is an apology or a resolution which is easier than what the manager was expecting.

If the manager is able to provide what the customer wants, then this is a quick and easy solution to the problem.

Taking into account all points of view

When dealing with a customer complaint it is important to consider the points of view of all parties involved.

Remember that all people are different, and your personal feelings, beliefs and attitudes are not necessarily those of the other person involved. Make sure you don't regard another person's feeling or thoughts negatively just because they may not be the same as, or agree with, yours.

Note too that encouraging, acknowledging and respecting other people's points of view does not mean that your eventual action or decision will reflect those points of view, or fully meet the expectations that those opinions may want, indicate or prefer.

Compromise may be an option, but complying with all legal and organisational requirements is a non-negotiable necessity.



What is a point of view?

A point of view is a position from which things are viewed. In terms of a complaint situation you should try to see things from the other person's point of view before making your final assessment and decision about a situation.

By doing this, you may gain an insight into how the other person is thinking and feeling. This will assist you in finding a speedy resolution that is more likely to be agreeable to all parties involved because the solution factors in feelings as well as other practical issues involved.

An important aspect of resolving a complaint is that the solution needs to accommodate the feelings of the people involved.

Organisation policies

Formal, written policies on dealing with customer complaints are useful because they:

- Provide guidance on what to do in order to resolve situations
- Give consistency when dealing with customers
- Relieve staff from having to make decisions – the policy sets out the decisions that management have made.



These policies may address issues such as:

- Who should deal with problems and complaints at different levels
- When management or security staff should be involved
- The limits of scopes of authority
- Situations under which the property will not try to resolve a conflict regardless of what the customer may allege
- Documentation that needs to be completed to record the complaint
- Training that staff should receive before they are expected to resolve issues on their own.



Pre-programmed decisions

Pre-programmed decisions are where a set policy or procedure is used to resolve an identified complaint.

Many establishments use pre-programmed decisions to assist with complaint resolution.

A pre-programmed decision is a decision that has been thought about and put in place to act as a standard establishment response to a given set of circumstances.

Pre-programmed decisions are usually put in place for situations that are common or can realistically be expected to occur. They provide consistency in the way customers are treated when a problem crops up and save staff having to determine what action they should take.

Where a pre-programmed decision is in place, staff usually have no authority to operate outside the parameters that the decision provides for.



Non-programmed decisions

Non-programmed decisions are where specific responses to individual complaints are determined on an individual case by case basis

If there is no pre-programmed action to follow then the manager has four basic options to choose from:

- Ask the person what it will take to fix the problem (as mentioned before)
- Meet the customer half-way or part-way
- Offer a formal apology
- Do nothing.



Doing nothing

It may be your genuine belief that, after a comprehensive, sensitive, sincere and considered assessment of the situation, that the parties involved warrant no action.

For example, if a conflict over a room reservation proves to be the fault of the customer (perhaps they booked a room at the wrong hotel, or made the booking for the wrong date), then it would be appropriate to simply explain the situation, offer a brief apology as appropriate for the purposes of civility and not make any offers of discounts or complimentary items.

Explain solution

Inform the customer of the action you wish to take. This course of action may have been proposed by them, by you, or arisen through negotiation. Check to see if this action is deemed acceptable.

Inform them of the timeframe that you expect to apply to implementing the resolution.

Never make up excuses or blame another colleague for a problem even if it may be true!



3.2 Agree and confirm action to resolve the complaint with the customer

Introduction

Once all possible solutions have been placed on the table for consideration, there needs to be a concerted effort to find a mutually agreed solution.

This process in itself may be a difficult activity with negotiations made by all parties to ensure an amicable solution can be reached.

At some stage though a solution must be reached and agreed.

Need to gain agreement on the solution

Once a viable solution to a conflict has been identified there needs to be genuine and definite agreement that implementation of that solution will bring an end to the problem.

Both parties involved need to understand that any further action on the issue will be discussed.

If this agreement cannot be obtained, implementation of a solution should be postponed until such agreement is forthcoming.

In some situations it can be useful and appropriate to help move things along by advising parties that the offer of a resolution is only available until a particular time and date.



Organisational constraints

Conflict resolution solutions must occur within any organisational constraints that may apply.

As already indicated these constraints may vary depending on the person involved or the exact circumstances of the complaint but they can be expected to include:

- Costs and budgets
- Written policies
- Availability
- Organisational constraints in this regard may also apply to situations where there is a lack of:
 - Replacement items
 - Services, including people to provide the service
 - Tickets.



Legal requirements

No solutions to a complaint can be proposed, or accommodated, where the venue (or staff) commit a breach of legislation.

For example, regardless of any factors that apply to a complaint with a customer, you cannot ever agree to activity that is in breach of local laws and regulations including, but certainly not limited to:

- Sell or provide liquor to an intoxicated person
- Allow minors to be illegally on licensed premises
- Supply liquor to minors otherwise in accordance with the law
- Provide tobacco products/cigarettes to minors
- Allowing minors into gaming areas.

Define agreed solution

In many cases a written course of action will be documented that outlines what action is to take place to resolve the complaint, as agreed by both parties.

This may include a record and commitment outlining:

- Actions or activities to take place
- Who is responsible for ensuring action takes place
- Who will undertake action
- Timelines
- Agreed standard of actions.



3.3 Demonstrate a commitment to the customer to resolve the complaint

Introduction

Now that agreement has been reached it must be actioned.

This should be done as soon as possible and must be exactly in accordance with the agreement that had been reached.

In most cases the solution may be quick and easy to resolve.

At other times the solution may take time and involve other staff members and departments.

Implement solution

This is usually what the guest wants you to do!

You now have to act to implement the agreed upon solution within a reasonable time frame.

In most cases it is not the role of the manager to implement these changes or solutions, but they must take responsibility for the problem and:

- Explain the complaint to the correct individual
- Ensure it is being completed within the specified time frame
- Keep the customer informed of the progress of the resolution. If ever there looks like being a delay in executing the resolution you absolutely must inform the guest at the earliest possible opportunity and provide a full explanation of the delay. Never let a delay just drag on and on, without keeping the guest up to date and informed
- Ensures the complaint has been resolved in accordance with the agreement and to the customer's satisfaction.



Only when the complaint has been resolved can the manager cease to be concerned with the matter.

3.4 Inform customer of outcome of investigation of complaint

Introduction

A manager must follow up on a complaint until it has been resolved to the satisfaction of the customer and organisational procedures.

In some cases the nature of the complaint may also be investigated.

Inform customer of outcome

Once the agreed course of action has been completed, it is essential to inform the customer of the outcome.

This can include:

- Providing documentation and/or evidence that supports customer complaint
- Providing documentation and/or evidence that does not support customer complaint
- Information (verbal or written) that directly relates to the complaint being investigated
- Information (verbal or written) that is presented in a calm and accurate manner



Keeping customer informed

It is essential that the manager or the person responsible for undertaking agreed actions to resolve the complaint, keep the customer informed of the progress towards the desired outcomes.

This also helps to show that the organisation's commitment and focus has not faltered.

Follow up with customer

As mentioned, it is important to ensure the customer is satisfied.

This involves checking with the customer to verify that the solution has successfully addressed their dissatisfaction and that the agreed solution has, in fact, been implemented.



Investigate complaint

As mentioned in Section 2.2 of this manual, one of the reasons for undertaking investigatory activities is to ascertain the causes of the problems. Resulting from this initial review, if the complaint warrants further investigation this should take place.

In a perfect world, every complaint should be investigated, as a complaint is often a clear sign there is a weakness in an aspect of service delivery or what is being 'offered' to the customer, which also incorporates the product aspect itself.

In reality though, not every complaint needs a thorough investigation. Some complaints may simply be caused by:

- Human error – a bed sheet was dirty or meal undercooked
- Cultural or language misunderstanding – customer with limited local language ability misunderstood menu item
- Communication error – someone forgot to pass on a message
- Problem with machinery – television in room didn't work or internet didn't connect
- Simple procedural error – there was a delay in getting room service to a room
- Uncontrollable event – everyone checked-out at the same time causing delays
- Something out of the control of the organisation, like a power cut or internet was slow.



However steps must be taken to investigate and resolve complaints which:

- Occur on a regular basis – delays in check-in or check-out
- Is of a serious nature – such as food poisoning, sexual harassment or death
- Can be improved – furniture and furnishings are out-dated
- Can be solved through training.



Not only is it important that the current complaint is resolved, but the chance of further reoccurrences of similar problems are eliminated or reduced at best.

Work Projects

It is a requirement of this Unit that you complete Work Projects as advised by your Trainer. You must submit documentation, suitable evidence or other relevant proof of completion of the project to your Trainer by the agreed date.

3.1 To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to research and identify:

- A range of possible solutions that can be implemented for 10 common complaints.

3.2. To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to research and identify:

- Possible legal or organisational constraints that can impact on possible solutions.

3.3. To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to research and identify:

- Steps associated with implementing the four solutions mentioned in Work Project 3.1.

3.4. To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to research and identify:

- How you can keep customer informed and updated regarding complaint resolution actions.
-

Summary

Determine and agree upon appropriate action to resolve complaint

Identify and review options to resolve procedures and guidelines:

- Determining possible solutions
- Explain solution.

Agree and confirm action to resolve the complaint with the customer:

- Need to gain agreement on the solution
- Organisational constraints
- Legal requirements
- Define agreed solution.

Demonstrate a commitment to the customer to resolve the complaint:

- Implement solution.

Inform customer of outcome of investigation of complaint:

- Keeping customer informed
- Follow up with customer
- Investigate complaint.

Element 4: Refer complaints

4.1 Identify complaints that require referral to other personnel or external bodies

Introduction

Whilst most complaints can be handled by individual staff members or managers within their scope of authority, at times complaints may need to be referred to executive management or external bodies.

Common complaints for referral

This normally relates to matters:

- Of a serious nature such as death, assault, theft etc.
- Where specialist skills, knowledge and equipment is needed to determine evidence such as financial statements and records from banks or security surveillance equipment
- Where criminal activity has taken place
- Where scope of authority is exceeded.



In these cases, the matter must be forwarded to the 'appropriate person'.

Referring complaints

Referring complaints is not necessarily an admission of failure on your part. It may quite simply be the most appropriate thing to do in the given situation. You might simply be unable to do, or authorise, whatever it is that is required to resolve the complaint.

A key to referring complaints is to do it quickly.

Where you have tried to resolve the situation yourself, and are quite obviously getting nowhere, you must quickly get someone else in to help.

When a complaint situation has arisen, time is critical, and your failure to notify the relevant person has the potential to greatly inflame the situation.

And, as we all know, when you are upset or annoyed, one minute seems like ten.

Finally, no-one expects you to be able to manage all complaints on your own, so don't try to battle on when you feel you're out of your depth.

Managing intoxicated patrons

As customers become more intoxicated, the more difficult it may be to handle the situation yourself. In many cases customers will understand the rules that apply and will abide by them in order to enjoy their time on the premises.

This is not always the case. At times situations may have got out of control resulting in other people being needed to bring the situation under control.



4.2 Refer complaint to appropriate personnel for follow-up in accordance with individual level of responsibility

Introduction

When it has been determined that a complaint needs to be referred to another person it must be done so in a timely manner.

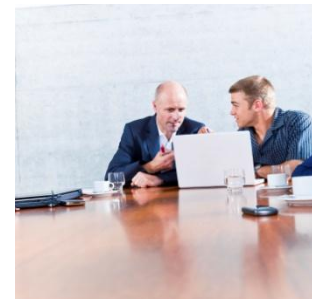
But who is the appropriate person?

Often this will be identified in policies and procedures. These documents will also indicate how these persons can be contacted.

Appropriate internal persons

The appropriate person, in some situations, may be:

- A co-worker who has more experience than you
- Higher manager
- Security
- External authorities such as the police, financial institutions or medical emergency services.



If a situation appears to be out of control it is important that the correct person or authority is called.

Whilst using internal sources of assistance are the first course of action, at times the situation may have gotten out of control and more serious action needs to be taken.

Every organisation should have a designated set of instructions and procedures to follow in the event of a variety of situations ranging from arguments, spiking of drinks, violence or medical harm, to name a few.

Staff must be aware of which type of assistance to contact whenever these situations arise.

Anytime a situation poses a risk it must be dealt with in a prompt manner abiding by all the laws required by the country.

Appropriate internal persons when handling intoxicated patrons

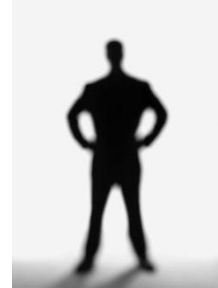
It must be remembered that the safety and health of staff and customers is the primary objective when handling complaints, especially instances involving intoxication.

As a staff member it is not a requirement for you to place yourself in harm's way if you feel you cannot handle the situation.

There are a number of appropriate people who can be called upon to provide assistance or to handle difficult situations involving alcohol.

These persons include:

- Supervisor/Management – they will make or authorise courses of action to take
- Security – they will have the expertise to deal with the manner
- DJ – they have the capacity to communicate not only with different authorities but can also communicate directly to the patrons within the venue.



Remember, if you feel you cannot handle a situation yourself, be smart and seek suitable support to handle any situation where you feel you are in harm.

Appropriate external persons

There are a number of suitable external sources that can be contacted including:

- Police – in the event of any activity that is breaking the law or likely to increase the risk of harm to all patrons and staff
- Fire – if there appears to be a likelihood of fire
- Ambulance – in the event a person requires medical assistance.



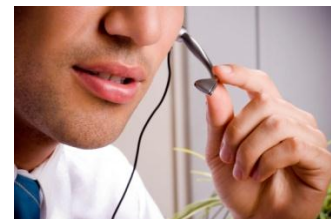
Reaching suitable external assistance

If a situation appears to be out of control it is important that the correct person or authority is called in a prompt manner.

Not only should managers state situations when each appropriate source of assistance should be notified, but also how to contact them.

Easy to reach contact details can include:

- Special button
- Posters with contact numbers
- Speed dials
- Other methods that are suitable.



4.3 Forward all necessary documentation including investigation reports to appropriate personnel

Introduction

In different sections of this manual the importance of keeping and maintaining accurate documentation and collection of evidence has been discussed.

The importance of this process is especially important when complaints are to be forwarded to other parties, either for them to follow up and resolve or to investigate further.

By having accurate and completed records and evidence, it helps them to gain an understanding of all aspects of the matter in a more effective manner.

Follow up with appropriate personnel

Whilst handing of written documentation and evidence is a great way to provide assistance to those who have been handed responsibility for undertaking further activity, it is also a worthwhile cause to meet with them personally to conduct a handover.

Benefits of conducting a personal handover include:

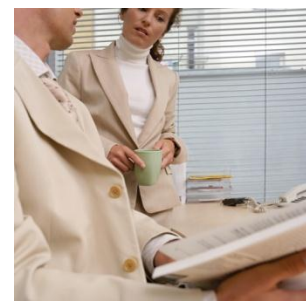
- Background information can be summarised
- Key points can be highlighted
- A first-hand account of activities can be explained, including reasoning for specific actions
- Sensitive or confidential information can be identified and explained
- Any queries can be clarified
- Any further information or questions that others may have can be answered.

4.4 Refer complaints which cannot be resolved to an appropriate person

Introduction

In Section 4.2 of this manual a number of internal and external persons to whom complaints can be referred to are identified.

Whilst this referral process may be in accordance with guidelines and enables access to a particular level of authority, responsibility or skill set, it is essential that the appropriate authorities are contacted in the event of an escalated complaint.



An escalated complaint

An escalated complaint may be seen as one where one or more of the following applies:

- The organisational policies specifically call for the complaint to be handled by management or some other nominated person
- Every genuine effort on your part to resolve the issue has been unsuccessful
- A situation where the customer is becoming agitated and you believe there is a chance the situation could further deteriorate into a physical confrontation
- A situation where the customer is swearing, making threats or drawing substantial attention from other customers or members of the public
- The customer is alleging impropriety, dishonesty or other fraudulent activity on behalf of a staff member
- A situation where the customer states they intend taking legal action in relation to the complaint
- A situation where the customer mentions they intend referring the complaint to the authorities including government agencies such as liquor licensing, health, gaming, other agencies
- A situation where the customer mentions they intend taking the issue to the media.



Whilst it is hoped that a customer complaint does not become an escalated matter, it is important that each establishment has clear guidelines and procedures for staff and management to follow when dealing with any type of complaint.

Summary

Whilst customer complaints are often seen in a negative light, they can be an opportunity to turn an unfortunate situation into a positive learning experience. Yes a complaint highlights a problem in some aspect of an establishment's operations, but when handled the right way can turn a dissatisfied customer into a loyal customer.

It is important to remember that many customers who have a complaint simply walk away and don't return. In fact they usually tell others about their negative experience, often with the establishment having no clue what has happened.

Not only does a customer complaint help an establishment to improve their products and services but provides an opportunity to demonstrate to the customer the value the establishment places on their patronage and its desire to meet their needs, wants and expectations.

Work Projects

It is a requirement of this Unit that you complete Work Projects as advised by your Trainer. You must submit documentation, suitable evidence or other relevant proof of completion of the project to your Trainer by the agreed date.

- 4.1 To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to research and identify complaints that require referral to other personnel or external bodies, including:
 - Common complaints for referral
 - When to refer complaints
 - Techniques used in managing intoxicated patrons.
 - 4.2. To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to research and identify:
 - Appropriate internal persons to refer complaints to
 - Appropriate external persons to refer complaints to.
 - 4.3. To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to research and identify:
 - Actions to take when referring complaints to another person to ensure they have all the required facts.
 - 4.4. To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to research and identify:
 - Types of escalated complaints.
-

Summary

Refer complaints

Identify complaints that require referral to other personnel or external bodies:

- Common complaints for referral
- Referring complaints
- Managing intoxicated patrons.

Refer complaint to appropriate personnel for follow-up in accordance with individual level of responsibility:

- Appropriate internal persons
- Appropriate external persons.

Forward all necessary documentation including investigation reports to appropriate personnel:

- Follow up with appropriate personnel.

Refer escalated complaints which cannot be resolved to an appropriate person:

- An escalated complaint
- Summary.

Presentation of written work

1. Introduction

It is important for students to present carefully prepared written work. Written presentation in industry must be professional in appearance and accurate in content. If students develop good writing skills whilst studying, they are able to easily transfer those skills to the workplace.

2. Style



Students should write in a style that is simple and concise. Short sentences and paragraphs are easier to read and understand. It helps to write a plan and at least one draft of the written work so that the final product will be well organised. The points presented will then follow a logical sequence and be relevant. Students should frequently refer to the question asked, to keep 'on track'. Teachers recognise and are critical of work that does not answer the question, or is 'padded' with irrelevant material. In summary, remember to:

- Plan ahead
- Be clear and concise
- Answer the question
- Proofread the final draft.

3. Presenting Written Work

Types of written work

Students may be asked to write:

- Short and long reports
- Essays
- Records of interviews
- Questionnaires
- Business letters
- Resumes.



Format

All written work should be presented on A4 paper, single-sided with a left-hand margin. If work is word-processed, one-and-a-half or double spacing should be used. Handwritten work must be legible and should also be well spaced to allow for ease of reading. New paragraphs should not be indented but should be separated by a space. Pages must be numbered. If headings are also to be numbered, students should use a logical and sequential system of numbering.

Cover Sheet

All written work should be submitted with a cover sheet stapled to the front that contains:

- The student's name and student number
- The name of the class/unit
- The due date of the work
- The title of the work
- The teacher's name
- A signed declaration that the work does not involve plagiarism.

Keeping a Copy

Students must keep a copy of the written work in case it is lost. This rarely happens but it can be disastrous if a copy has not been kept.

Inclusive language

This means language that includes every section of the population. For instance, if a student were to write 'A nurse is responsible for the patients in her care at all times' it would be implying that all nurses are female and would be excluding male nurses.

Examples of appropriate language are shown on the right:

Mankind	<i>Humankind</i>
Barman/maid	<i>Bar attendant</i>
Host/hostess	<i>Host</i>
Waiter/waitress	<i>Waiter or waiting staff</i>

Recommended reading

Barlow, Janelle, 2008 (2nd edition); *A Complaint Is a Gift: Recovering Customer Loyalty When Things Go Wrong*; Berrett-Koehler Publishers

Cook, Sarah, 2012 (1st edition); *Complaint Management Excellence: Creating Customer Loyalty through Service Recovery*; Kogan Page

Strauss, Bernd, 2005 (1st edition); *Complaint Management: The Heart of CRM*; South-Western Educational Pub

In addition

The following is sourced from 'Trove: National Library of Australia' at <http://trove.nla.gov.au/>.

Barrows, Clayton W & Powers, Thomas F., 1931-, (author.) & Reynolds, Dennis E. (Dennis Edward), (author.) 2012, *Introduction to Management in the Hospitality Industry*, Tenth Edition / Clayton W. Barrows, Tom Powers, Dennis Reynolds, Wiley, Hoboken, New Jersey

Cichy, Ronald F & Hickey, Philip J 2012, *Managing service in food and beverage operations*, 4th ed, American Hotel & Lodging Educational Institute, Lansing, Mich

Culinary Institute of America 2009, *Remarkable service*, 2nd ed, John Wiley & Sons, Hoboken, N.J

DuBrin, Andrew J 2015, *Human relations: interpersonal job-oriented skills*, Twelfth edition, Boston Pearson

Ford, Robert C & Sturman, Michael C. (Michael Craig) & Heaton, Cherrill P 2012, *Managing quality service in hospitality: how organizations achieve excellence in the guest experience*, International ed, Delmar, Cengage Learning, Clifton Park, N.Y

Futrell, Charles 2014, *Fundamentals of selling : customers for life through service*, Thirteenth edition, New York, NY McGraw-Hill/Irwin

KINNI, TED & Kinni, Theodore B., 1956- & Disney Institute 2011, *Be our guest: perfecting the art of customer service*, Revised and updated ed, Disney Editions, New York

Lillicrap, D. R & Cousins, John A 2010, *Food and beverage service*, 8th ed, Hodder Education, London

Locker, Kitty O & Kaczmarek, Stephen Kyo 2014, *Business communication: building critical skills*, Sixth edition, New York, NY McGraw-Hill/Irwin, a business unit of The McGraw-Hill Companies, Inc

Singaravelavan, R 2012, *Food and beverage service*, Oxford University Press, New Delhi, India

Trainee evaluation sheet

Receive and resolve customer complaints

The following statements are about the competency you have just completed.

Please tick the appropriate box	Agree	Don't Know	Do Not Agree	Does Not Apply
There was too much in this competency to cover without rushing.	☐	☐	☐	☐
Most of the competency seemed relevant to me.	☐	☐	☐	☐
The competency was at the right level for me.	☐	☐	☐	☐
I got enough help from my trainer.	☐	☐	☐	☐
The amount of activities was sufficient.	☐	☐	☐	☐
The competency allowed me to use my own initiative.	☐	☐	☐	☐
My training was well-organised.	☐	☐	☐	☐
My trainer had time to answer my questions.	☐	☐	☐	☐
I understood how I was going to be assessed.	☐	☐	☐	☐
I was given enough time to practice.	☐	☐	☐	☐
My trainer feedback was useful.	☐	☐	☐	☐
Enough equipment was available and it worked well.	☐	☐	☐	☐
The activities were too hard for me.	☐	☐	☐	☐

The best things about this unit were:

The worst things about this unit were:

The things you should change in this unit are:

Trainee self-assessment checklist

As an indicator to your Trainer/Assessor of your readiness for assessment in this unit please complete the following and hand to your Trainer/Assessor.

Receive and resolve customer complaints

		Yes	No*
Element 1: Identify and analyse the complaint			
1.1	Receive and accurately record a verbal complaint using active listening and empathy techniques	☐	☐
1.2	Identify through appropriate communication techniques the exact nature of the customer complaint	☐	☐
1.3	Maintain register or complaint file/s in accordance with the requirements of the enterprise information system	☐	☐
Element 2: Respond to complaints			
2.1	Process complaints in accordance with organisational standards, policies and procedures	☐	☐
2.2	Obtain and review documentation in relation to complaints	☐	☐
2.3	Update register of complaints/disputes	☐	☐
Element 3: Determine and agree upon appropriate action to resolve complaint			
3.1	Identify and review options to resolve the complaint within enterprise policy, procedures and guidelines	☐	☐
3.2	Agree and confirm action to resolve the complaint with the customer	☐	☐
3.3	Demonstrate a commitment to the customer to resolve the complaint	☐	☐
3.4	Inform customer of outcome of investigation of complaint	☐	☐
Element 4: Refer complaints			
4.1	Identify complaints that require referral to other personnel or external bodies	☐	☐
4.2	Refer complaint to appropriate personnel for follow-up in accordance with individual level of responsibility	☐	☐
4.3	Forward all necessary documentation including investigation reports to appropriate personnel	☐	☐
4.4	Refer complaints which cannot be resolved to an appropriate person	☐	☐

Statement by Trainee:

I believe I am ready to be assessed on the following as indicated above:

Signed: _____

Date: _____

Note:

For all boxes where a **No*** is ticked, please provide details of the extra steps or work you need to do to become ready for assessment.

